I am what I think you think I am

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We are many things, we become many people, we live different lives inside one life of ours. We learn, we grow, we change, we change yet not becoming the change in itself, we are always becoming someone yet rarely be someone same for 2 days in a raw, we are a plethora of contradictions. So, the question arises; who are we actually? Who am I? What decides what I am. The genetics, the environmental, the knowledge we gather over the years or something else? The answer probably is "All of these", and that's true in a way, we are afterall the sum total of all the things that ever happen to us, that is precisely what makes us each unique.

However, there's an argument to be made about the influence of perceived judgements of others on our development and our very being. Focus on the word "perceived". There are psychological studies performed to childeren, that randomly pick some childeren in a class and tell them that their teachers and peers think highly of them and expect them to do good in exams. And somehow, this randomly selected group of childeren outperforms others and, outperform the average and outperform their own previous performances to score better in the exam. These

subset of studies do not involve "real external judgement" because for most part the teachers and other peers do not really think of them as particularly smarter or hardworking. It is infact, the very fact that they themselves believe that others think of them like that and then try to live up to that. Hence in a way changing themselves based on their perceived judgement of others.

While its true that so much of ourselves is determined by genetics, environment, upbringing and other factors which are for all sense and purposes outside our control, and I do not want to underplay them. But the impact of this "perceived judgement" remains a huge factor influencing the influenceable part of our nature. It pertains to the deep human desire of meeting expectations, or being what they ought to be. The power of this perceived judgement on us is powerful and slightly frightening. In the right situations, it can allow us to outgrow our limitations and become better, and ~~as~~ under the wrong influences, it can make us monsters, or atleast numb to the evil that we or others around us may possess. You can tell a man that others thing he is a kind man and he may well live his life trying to be just to the label.

"When you clean the mirror, the reflection you see of yourself becomes clean"

Or you may tell a man that others think of him as a heartless killer machine, and he may spend his life being the killer machine.

There are 3 possible levels of explanation to this phenomena; first being the evolutionary need for acceptance into the community. Being the social animals, for the majority of human existence, our survival very much depended on being part of a community and thus the powerful need to conform to what others think of us. Secondly, the element of judgement is transformed into "received judgement" by the mere fact that we lack access to other people's thought and opinions. Our brains are constantly trying to process the social cues to find out what others think of us and then being that (actually there exist credible scientific theories that prelude to this complex taste of processing social cues as the major factor that made human brain grow and become more complex than other animals). The third and the deepest explanation has to do with the question that why we want to become ~~what~~ aligned with this received judgement. And to me, the answer is the fundamental human desire for meaning. He finds himself gaining consciousness in a piece of flesh

You cannot change what others think of you, what you can change what you think about others & when you do, when you humanize them & construct a positive mental image of them, that will change what you think they think, thus changing you. The love you show to others would come back to you.

and then to his conscious demand him the meaning of his existence. While all the genetic and external factors determines our physical traits and social behaviours, the question of "Who I am and why I am" remains lurking in the subconscious. And since, for most or all, there exists no satisfactory answer to this question, the perceived judgments come in there to fill the gap and tell the man what he is and what he is ought to be. In a way, its the lack of personal meaning that makes us so prone to perceived external labels.

While I am in no way capable of saying whether this pronesses to perceived judgements is inherently good or bad, or where to turn for a personal meaning in absence of others (it raises the hegelian question of whether consciousness can exist in vacuum in absence of others), but I can say this; It is afterall a perceived judgement, a reflection of us in the constructed mental image of others and only remembring that it is much more about us than others, helps us to not feel like pawns and gives us back the power over our own selves. We could alter the perceival image and we are in no way bounded by what we think the others think of us, because even if we can't change what others think, we can change what we think they think!